Mano.

Your everyday college senior, through every setback



Overview

Fear of failure is now the biggest driver of stress among Indian students, yet most still turn to a friend before a counsellor.

Mano is an AI companion that listens like a college senior.
It acknowledges the struggle without making students feel small, asks what happened, and offers advice only when asked, in the language students already use with each other.



RESEARCH

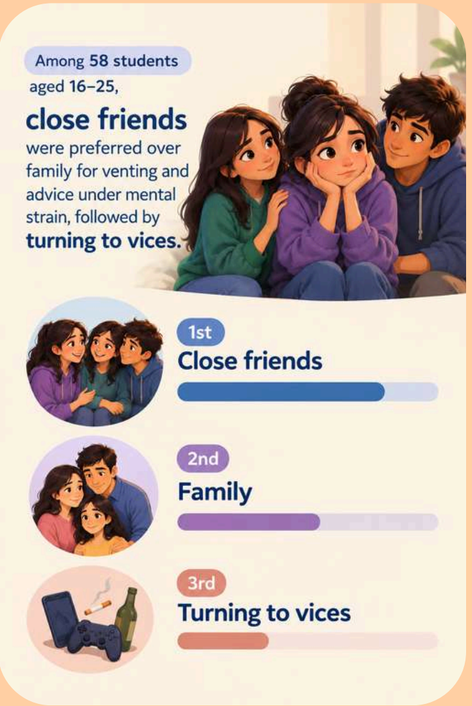
• Nearly 60% of India’s mental health burden affects people under 35. Ages 15-29 is the most affected with **60% among them in ages 15–24**.

• Academic pressure and fear of failure are the **biggest drivers** of student stress, followed by personal relationships.

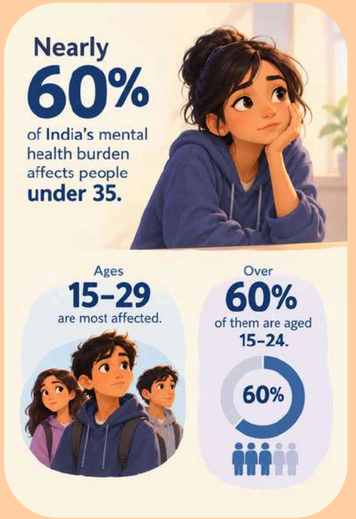
• Among 58 students aged 16–25, **close friends were preferred** over family for venting and advice under mental strain, followed by turning to vices.

• A 2026 study found 83% of Indian adolescents had used chatbots, with **79% finding them helpful** for personal issues. Anonymity and quick responses were most valued.









USER PERSONA

Ritika Sharma, 23



Final year, B.Tech CS
Pune

Bio – Pursuing placements and facing rejections for the past two months

Pain Points

- Repeated final-round rejections
- Self doubt
- Wondering if four years of effort mattered

Needs

- Someone who asks what happened, not what's next
- To be able to talk out her frustrations
- Permission to not seem "fine" all the time

Arjun Mehta, 18



Class 12, PCM
Kota, Rajasthan

Bio – Stays in a hostel for JEE prep. Not scoring satisfactory grades in the tests amidst peers scoring much higher

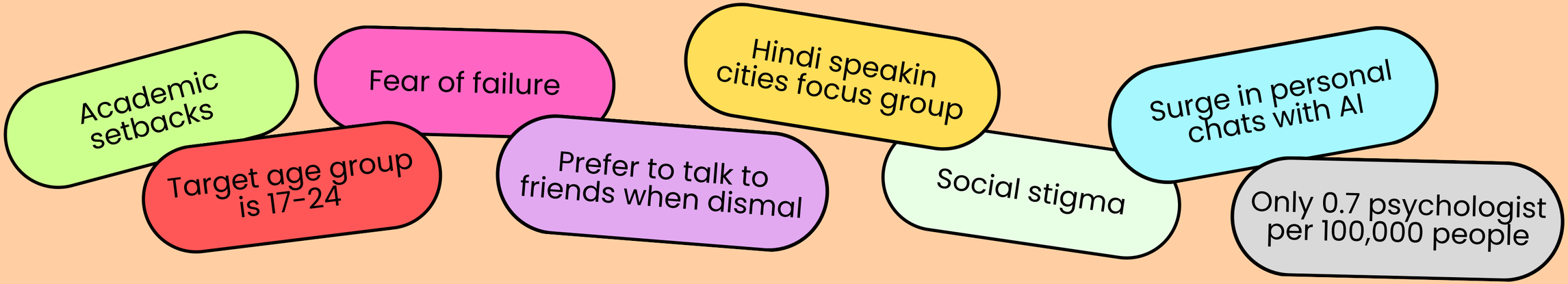
Pain Points

- Constantly comparing rank to hostel-mates
- Self doubt
- Feeling anxious about the future

Needs

- A place to admit fear without it becoming study advice
- Someone who can be a mental support
- To feel like he is not alone in this space

PROBLEM DEFINING

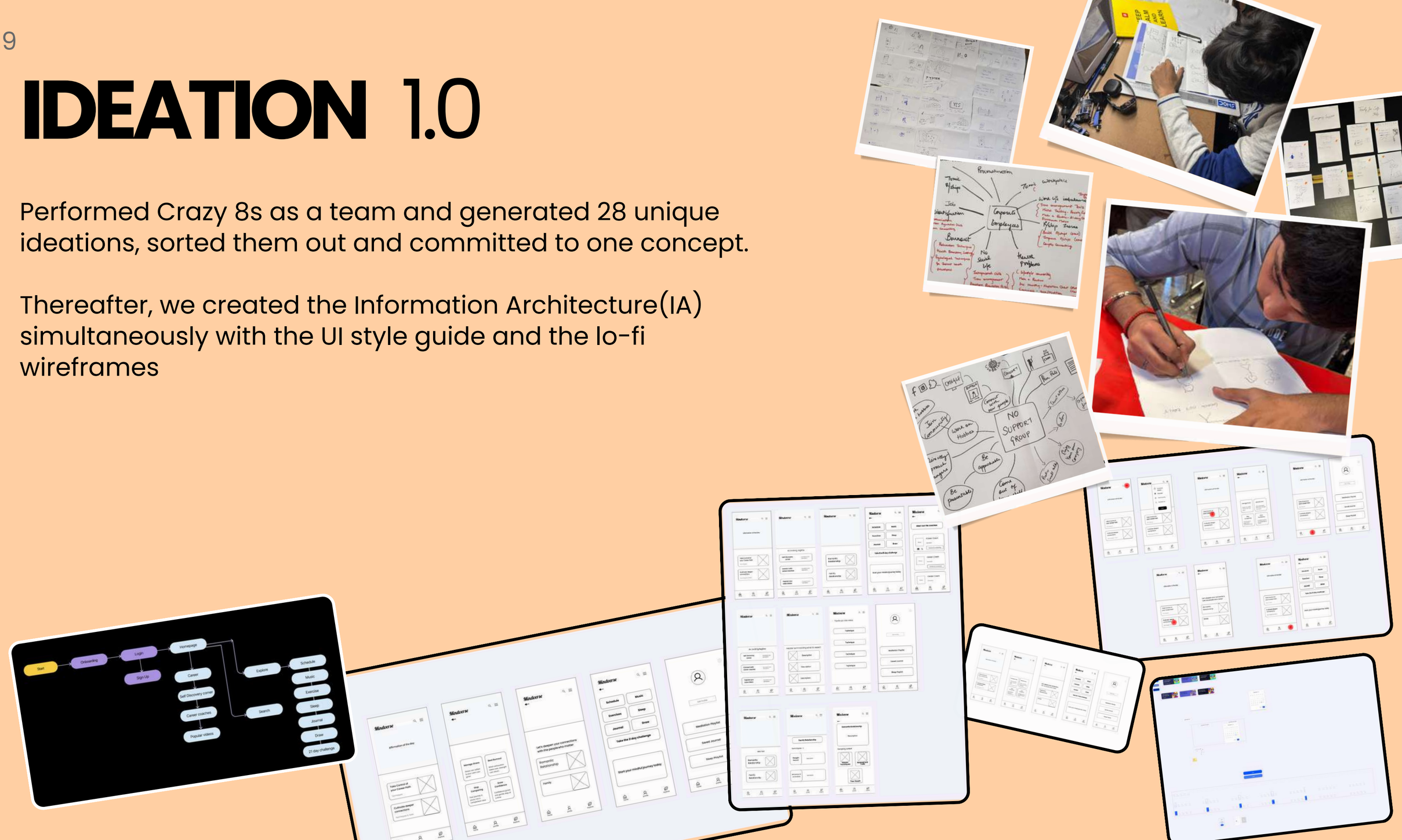


How might we create a warm and understanding space that helps students (17-24) navigate academic setbacks with reassurance and confidence ?

IDEATION 1.0

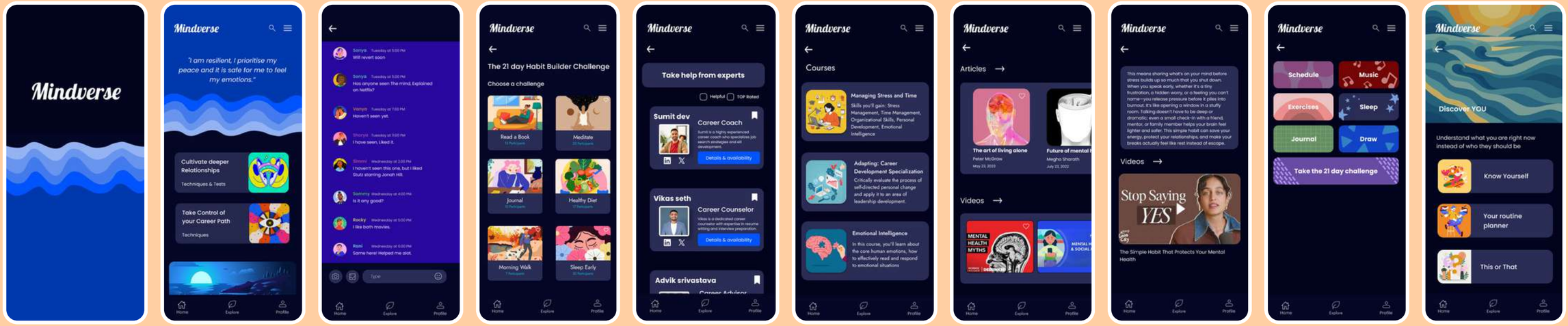
Performed Crazy 8s as a team and generated 28 unique ideations, sorted them out and committed to one concept.

Thereafter, we created the Information Architecture(IA) simultaneously with the UI style guide and the lo-fi wireframes



INITIAL SOLUTION

Mindverse was our initial solution, a mental wellness super app for students with academic setbacks. It offered curated content, 1:1 career coaching, community chat, self-help courses, guided meditation, stress-relief drawing, a 21-day habit challenge, and sleep and clarity exercises.



User and mentor feedback revealed key friction points in Mindverse



"I didn't know where to start."

Too many options, with no clear starting point for a distressed student.

"I just wanted to vent, but everything felt like homework."

Courses, guided exercises, and the 21-day challenge all demanded effort, adding to the burden instead of relieving it.

"The career coach thing is locked behind payment, so I never even tried it."

Students can’t afford paid mental health counselor

“Nothing felt specific to my problem, just generic CBT-style content.”

Videos and articles felt clinical, not personal.

Reflecting on the problem...

Analyzing the feedback alongside our primary research and problem statement gave us clarity.

Students did not need a prescription of CBT exercises or generic self-help tools. We had assumed the right tools would make them feel better. But this was a superficial clinical fix for a deeply human problem.

What students actually wanted was to feel understood and acknowledged, know they were not alone in their setback, and have a friendly, mentor-like figure who genuinely cared and guided them, rather than a library of tools to navigate alone.



Decision I took

I deprioritized Mindverse due to these drawbacks, revisited the problem statement, and began iterating on new ideas.

IDEATION 2.0

Relooked at the previous ideas, features already built for Mindverse and explored new ideations, now with a newer understanding about the user’s goal



AI that remembers past setbacks and references them naturally
captain anxiety

An always-on elder-sibling companion who listens first, advises only if asked
captain anxiety

A quiet room with a landline-style phone connecting directly to a trained peer listener
captain anxiety

Advice shaped by a student's specific family and academic context
captain anxiety

Journaling AI that spots a student's own recurring patterns over time
captain anxiety

Support tailored entirely to one description of a student's situation
captain anxiety

An app building a private, evolving story of one student's journey
captain anxiety

A community bulletin board mapping which seniors are open to being approached about specific struggles (placements, backlogs)
captain anxiety

AI mentor that remembers specific goals and checks in on them
captain anxiety

Chat that asks what happened instead of offering a coping script
captain anxiety

Companion that mirrors a student's own tone, language, and humor
captain anxiety

A campus tradition where final-year students leave behind handwritten advice cards for the incoming batch, no names attached
captain anxiety

Treats a specific failure differently from a generic one
captain anxiety

Companion that asks what's actually different about each student's stress
captain anxiety

A student's exact rejection story shapes the next conversation
captain anxiety

A personal setback timeline reflected back to show real progress
captain anxiety

A campus mural project where students anonymously paint or write about a setback with date, visible to the whole college
captain anxiety

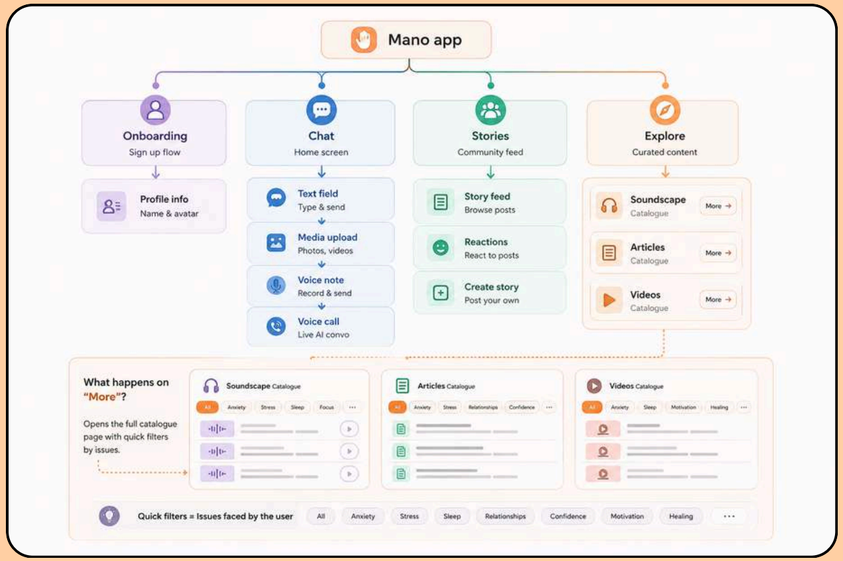
A printed zine, made entirely of anonymous student setback stories, distributed free every semester
captain anxiety

A campus radio show, student-run, where anonymous setback stories are read aloud with music
captain anxiety

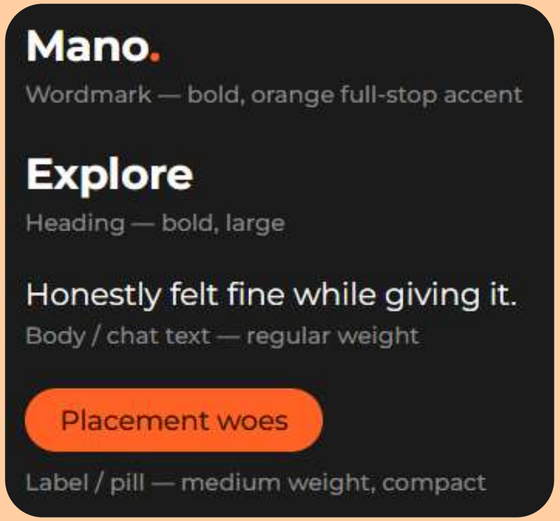
Tracks what's worked for this student before, avoids what hasn't
captain anxiety

An app to connect to interested alumni of the past 5 years throughout state
captain anxiety

Building the foundation

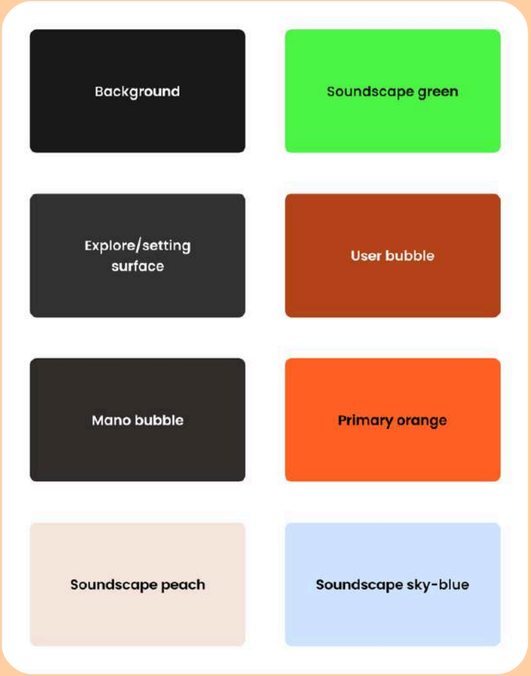


Information architecture



Type style

Montserrat and a narrow type scale keep the focus on the conversation itself, not on the UI competing for attention



Color style

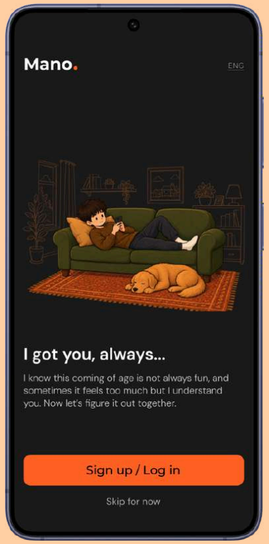
A near-black base feels quiet and private, while orange brings warmth

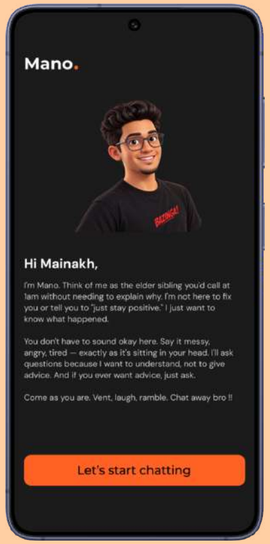
FINAL SOLUTION

Prototype link - Click me (I have provided a prototype link at the end of the presentation as well)

Mano.

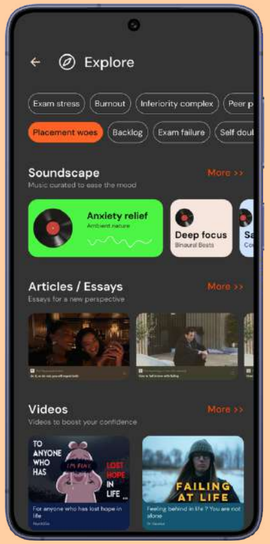
Mano feels less like advice and more like an honest chat with an elder sibling, helping students understand their setbacks and feel less alone.

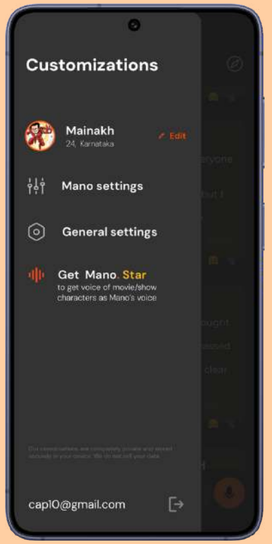










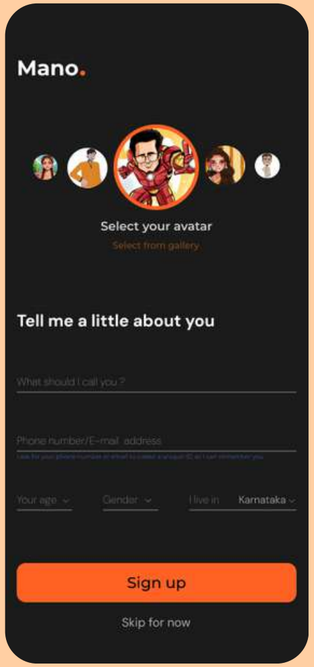


Onboarding



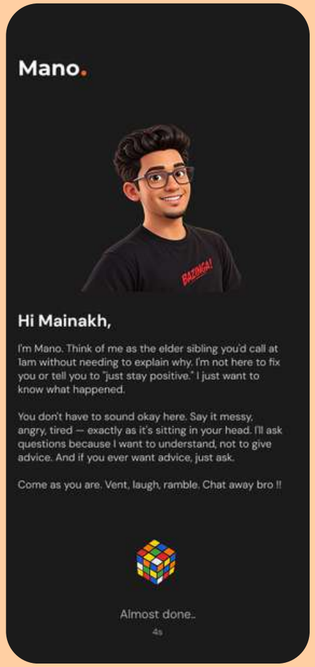
Greeting in a warm tone which makes users feel at ease

Explore first, sign up when ready, giving users control



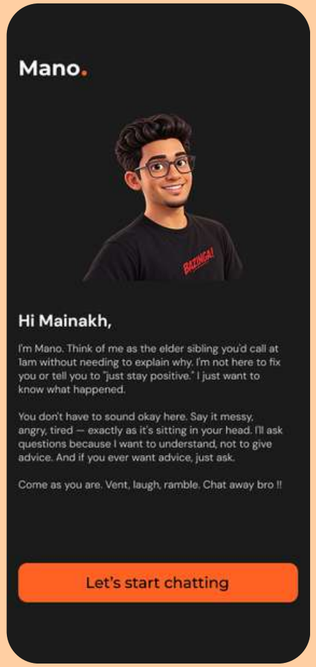
Using informal copy asking for information, building cordiality

Reasoning on asking personal info like email builds trust



A meaningful message keeps the wait from feeling wasted.

Timer shows the time left, giving info about the system



A CTA lets users move on when they're ready, instead of changing screens automatically.



The default chat interface

A fairly short onboarding process completed

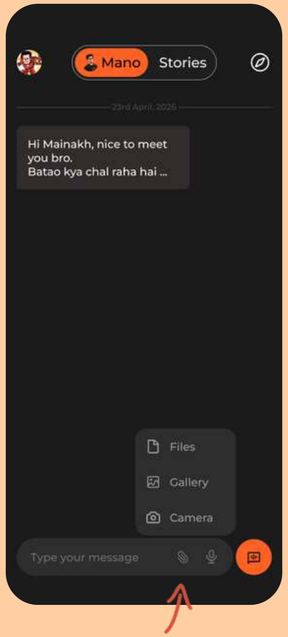
Main chat interface



Responds like someone you know, not a CBT-trained psychologist.

An empathetic senior who reasons with students toward feasible next steps, without diagnosing or deciding for them.

Hands off to a safety response if it detects real crisis level distress



Adding file, photo or clicked picture in chat



Voice note can be sent for easier conversations



Chatting 1:1 with the Mano companion

Easily exit the conversation by clicking on X



The Mano avatar changes its expression based on the theme of talk

Orange rim shows the tenor of conversation



Toggle switch to go to “Stories” section

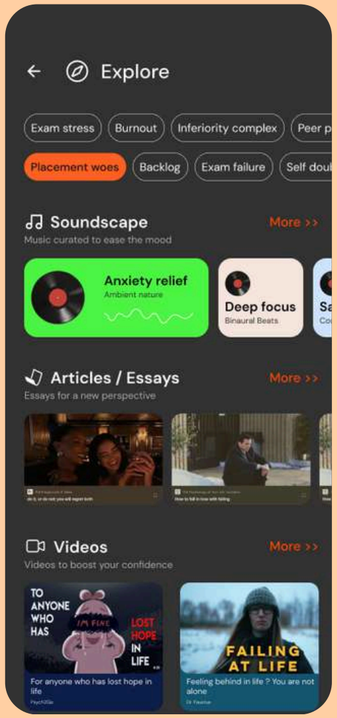
Stories of setbacks, rejections and comeback anaonymously posted for resonating with user

Explore resources



Explore page can be accessed from the top right compass icon

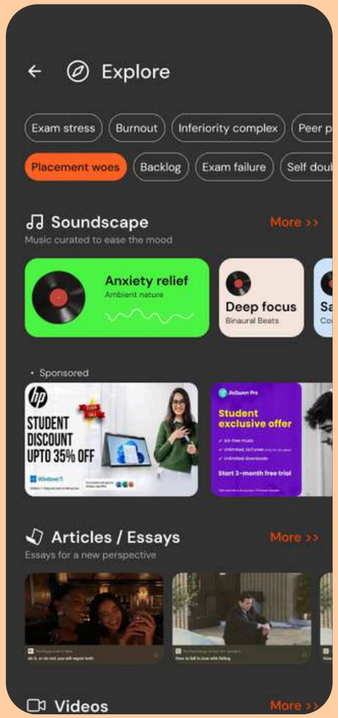
The Explore page slides in from the right → left



Quick filter to select feed basis the type of issue the user feels

Music frequencies curated to ease the mood of distress into a calmer sense of being

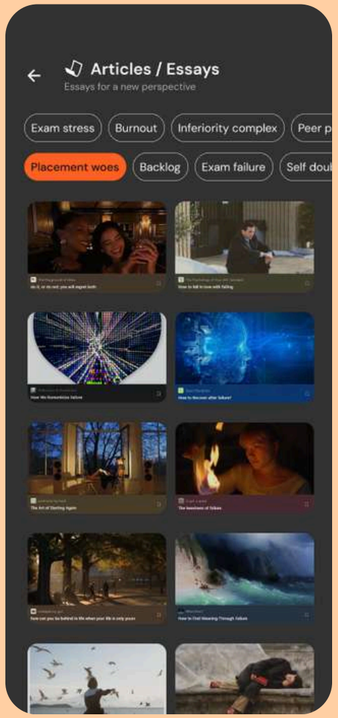
Essays, articles, and videos that help users reframe failure and find their next step.



Sponsored ads targeted at the student user are displayed in explore page



Tapping on “More” takes user to the complete catalog of the resource



The quick filter is retained in the “More” page of the resource too

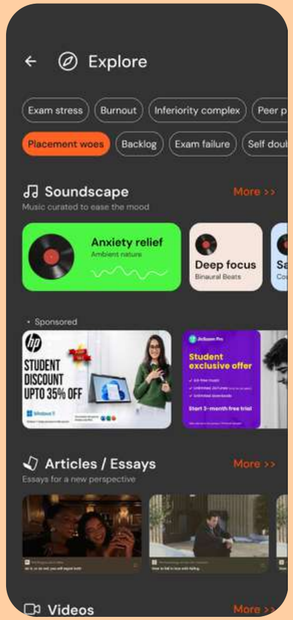
A back button to easily exit the page

Revenue stream

1



The top right compass icon opens into explore page

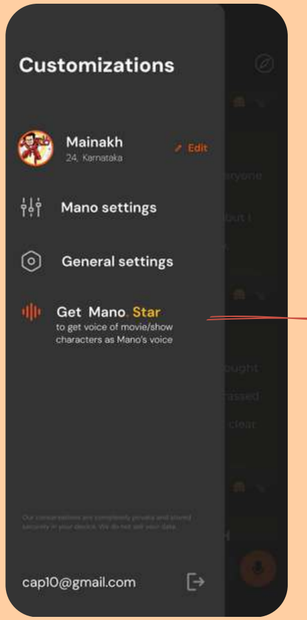


Relevant ads appear in Explore, the app's least intrusive section.

2



The top left icon of avatar takes to the subscription page



The settings panel has the option to avail Mano. Star, the premium of Mano



Mano. Star provides an ad free exploring and the offer to select a new avatar as another companion which comes with their unique personality traits

BUSINESS MODEL

Where would I sell ?

- **Colleges & universities** - Primary B2B2C channel; institutions pay, students use Mano free.
- **Coaching institutes** - A strong fit for high-pressure JEE/NEET environments.
- **Direct-to-student** - Freemium upgrades and ad-free Explore.



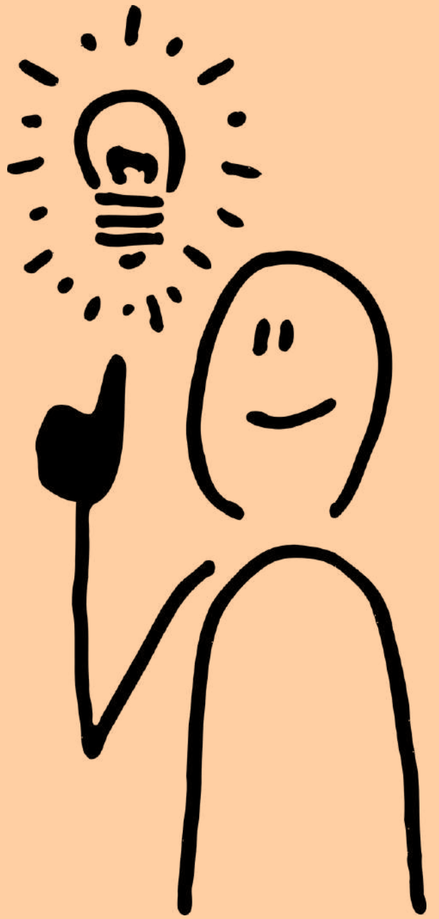
Why It Works

In January 2026, UGC made it mandatory for every Indian college to set up 24×7 mental health support and have one counsellor per 100 students. Most colleges can't hire and fund that overnight, that's the gap Mano fills.

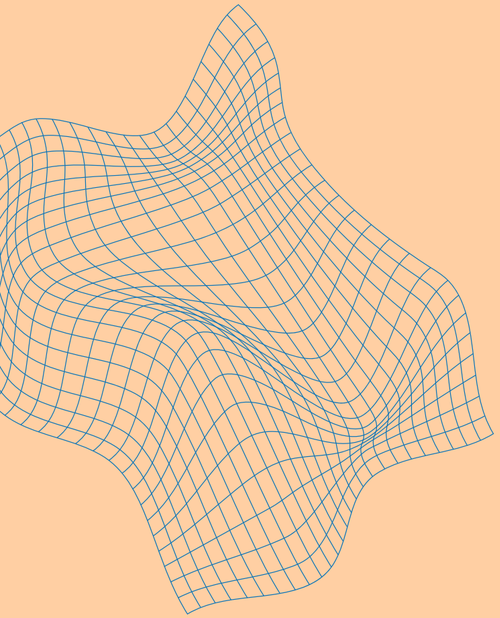
- **Covers the gap** - students talk to Mano before they'd walk into a counsellor's office
- **Cheaper than hiring** - fraction of the cost, works for every student at once
- **Ready to go** - no setup, students start immediately

Learnings from the project

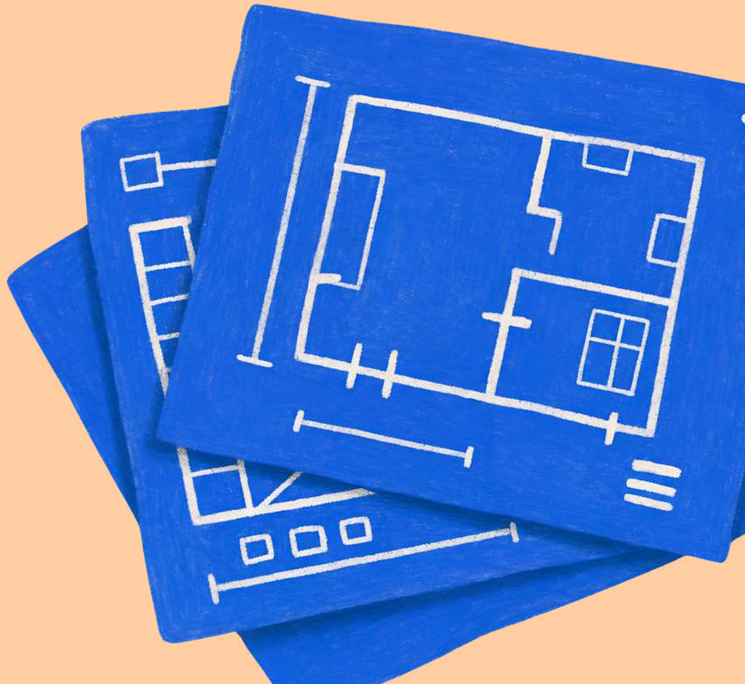
- **Design is iterative.** I explored several directions, but feedback showed one wasn’t enough. Revisiting the problem led me to Mano.
- **I moved from designing for features to designing for the emotion.** I started with features, then realized the real work was understanding the user’s emotional friction
- **A product has to work for the business as much as the user.** Considering both together changed how I evaluated every idea.
- **Constraints shape design, they don't block it.** I initially wanted premium personalities voiced like movie characters, but legal and economic constraints pushed me toward a more original solution.



Prototype link to Mano.



Click me




THANK YOU!
BAZINGA!